

CEREAL

ALONG WITH A COMPLETE BREAKFAST, PROVIDES ESSENTIAL VITAMINS, MINERALS AND SHORT STORIES!

DUTY AND SELF

CHARLOTTE, WHAT IS IT? OH, AND IN ENGLISH PLEASE.” ↴ “A BOX, CAPTAIN, WITH SOMETHING IN IT.” ↴ SHE LAUGHED SOFTLY, “GOOD THING FOR A BOX TO HAVE. QUARANTINE AND OPEN IT, CHARLOTTE. I WANT TO KNOW WHAT’S INSIDE.” ↴ “YES, CAPTAIN.”

She continued down the hall to the supply room. Quickly she fetched a pair of batteries and turned to leave. She paused in the doorway, feeling the batteries in her hand. She hadn’t been around another living being in years. She’d never had a very active social life but it was depressing at times having to get new batteries to keep her sex life going. Oh, well. These things happened. She continued on her way to quarantine, pausing for a moment at her quarters to place the batteries on her desk.

“Charlotte, status. And in English please.”

“The box has been prepared in quarantine as ordered, captain.”

“Thanks, Charlotte. Dangerous?”

“Negative, captain. The contents are dormant.”

She paused a moment, confused, “Dormant, Charlotte?”

“Yes, captain. A sleeping life form.”

“There’s something alive in there, Charlotte?”

*by Kyle
Mawhiney*

“Affirmative, Captain.”

She wondered a moment before stepping into the quarantine chamber. She stepped over to the box, slowly reaching out a hand to touch it. The cold plastic burned her fingers slightly as she felt along the sides of the box for a way to open it. She stumbled over a button on the side of the box and stabbed it with her finger. She darted back a step as the sides of the box fell open, scraping her legs. She knelt down beside the thing in the box and reached to touch its flesh.

“Hey, whoa, hello. Huh?” a weary voice blurted.

She started a bit,

“You can talk.”

He was silent a few moments before speaking again in a pained voice, “Barely. Where am I? Who are you? The other appropriate questions. You know the routine.”

“I am acting captain Theresa Magellan of the

i a+b=thing t

Trebuchet class warship *Kerensky*. The year is eighty-one fourteen of the Common Union calendar. How long have you been drifting?"

He was again silent for a few moments, "I went in in nine twenty-four Anarch Amalgam... That would make it something like forty-four years. Acting captain? What does that mean?"

"It means that after the accident I am the surviving officer most qualified to command."

"So the captain is dead?"

"Yes."

"How many survivors are there?"

"One."

"One?"

"Yes, one. Are you an Anarchist?"

He was silent for a long moment before answering, "Yes."

She nodded, "Very well. You are under arrest by order of Common Union law. Are you going to resist?"

"No. How long have you been alone?"

She slipped her pistol from her belt, letting it dangle loosely in her hand, "Please come with me. The accident occurred about twelve years ago."

She heard him stand slowly, slipping a bit on the frozen sides of the box. He took her hand and followed beside her as she led him through the ship to the brig. She squeezed his fingers in her own, exalting in human touch. Twelve years since she'd even been near another human being. She paused

outside the brig, tilting her head back to address the computer, and started as she felt cool lips pressed to her own. She relaxed quickly, falling against him, shuddering a bit as his chill arms closed around her.

He laughed quietly as he released her, "Sorry. I'm just a bit cold and you're very warm."

She didn't move from where she lay against him, "I don't mind. But I do need to get you into a cell."

He hugged her to him and again slipped his hand into hers, following her lead.

"Charlotte, open cell seven."

"Yes, captain."

She led him inside quietly and turned to hug him again. He softly kissed her, his flesh slowly warming. She pushed him away after a moment and smiled.

"I have to attend to my duties. You will be dealt with when I'm done."

"Fine. I'll wait here. As if I have a choice in the matter."

She laughed with him for a brief moment before turning and leaving the cell. She heard the door slide closed behind her as she left the brig, heading for her quarters.

"Charlotte, seal cell seven and hard flush the contents."

"Yes, captain. Procedure initiated."

She sat on her bed, fingering a battery in her hand. The sound of air violently fleeing into space blew through the ship. For the first time she wished the accident hadn't taken her tears.

SP LOST ACE

**MAN
BOARD**

CELLPHONE

Walking. I'm drinking day-old coffee, out of cigarettes and I'm walking. Having just woken up and not caring about reality until I reach the store and I have a Camel soft pack in my hand. I am more or less ignorant of my surroundings. I cross a random side street as though it isn't there. About halfway across I hear the sound of breaks screeching and a horn honking. I look to my right and see a black BMW roughly four inches from me.

by
Luc Thiers

Instead of continuing onward as I normally would have, I simply stand there as a man in a fairly expensive looking suit gets out of his car and shakes his cell-phone at me while yelling, "You fucking degenerate punk! Why don't you watch where you're going? I could have killed you! You're going to make me late you little puke! Fuck you!"

I stand there watching him; wondering if he speaks to his own kids this way.

He continues with his pointless onslaught of insults:

"You crazy freak! Goddamn it! I'm going to be late! I could've hit you! I'm going to be late now, you fucking punk!"

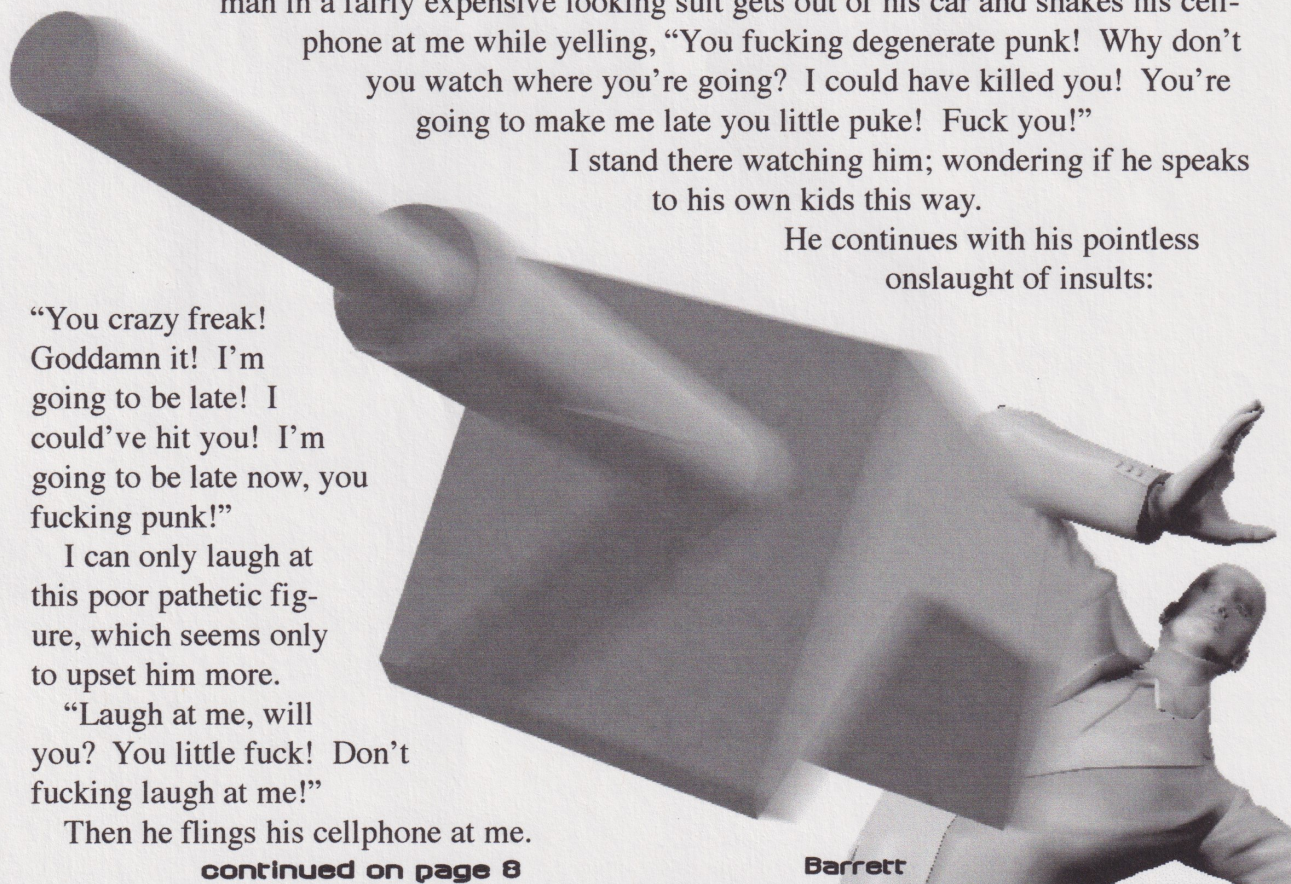
I can only laugh at this poor pathetic figure, which seems only to upset him more.

"Laugh at me, will you? You little fuck! Don't fucking laugh at me!"

Then he flings his cellphone at me.

continued on page 8

Barrett



Panic & Revulsion in WASHINGTON D.C.

Part V - Laughing All the Way From The Bank

(Almost everything in this entire series is as remembered. As the story progresses, I will let you, the reader, in on the things that didn't actually happen. The names of the innocent have been changed only to protect the guilty.)

Jason and I needed to find some nice local girls willing to take us in, so we went to M and 9th Streets to a club called The Bank.

Long ago, it used to be a proud financial institution.

After being

abandoned for a few years, it opened as a club called The Fifth Column.

The five large

marble pillars made it easy to spot. The immovable line outside consisted of about thirty-five people, and that was a problem. But with a lanyard dangling a few backstage passes around my neck, a made up story about Alice Cooper, and a bribe of a

Smokin' Grooves pass I was able to convince the door guy that we held enough VIP status to be allowed in immediately, but failed to persuade him to let us in for free. I didn't want to force the issue.

The door led us through a small alcove that opened into a large room. The walls were pounding with 128 beat per minute techno.

Three steps out of the alcove and we had seats at the corner of the bar. In the two minutes of paying the cover charge, \$8 each, and for two White Russians, another \$8 a piece plus tip (but worth it,) we had blown \$34.

"Thirty-four dollars in two minutes!" Jason informed me, "We only have three bucks left!"

Written by
**BRIAN
BARRETT**



"Welcome to the big city!" I toasted, still confident that the fates would deliver us safely along our journey.

Jason shared my optimism. "To trouble!" He exclaimed while lifting his glass to his smile.

"To crisis!" I concurred.

"To the trials of the soul!" a well dressed, olive complexioned gentleman joined in, finishing what looked like a vodka and orange juice. He dropped a freshly minted Franklin onto the counter and, without asking, immediately ordered for us.

"I'd like three shots of Jagermeister," he then pointed at me, "three shots for him," he pointed at Jason, "and three shots for him," he gestured with his thumb to his equally fashioned drinking buddies sitting on his other side, "and three rounds for them and three for you."

The bartender complied as quickly as she could, which was record breaking speed. She lined up 21 glasses in three rows of seven and started pouring.

"So, you guys having a good time?" The man inquired as if it was his job to be the activities coordinator for the entire city, and genuinely needed our opinion to be positive or the Director of Entertainment would be served his walking papers when he got to his desk in the morning.

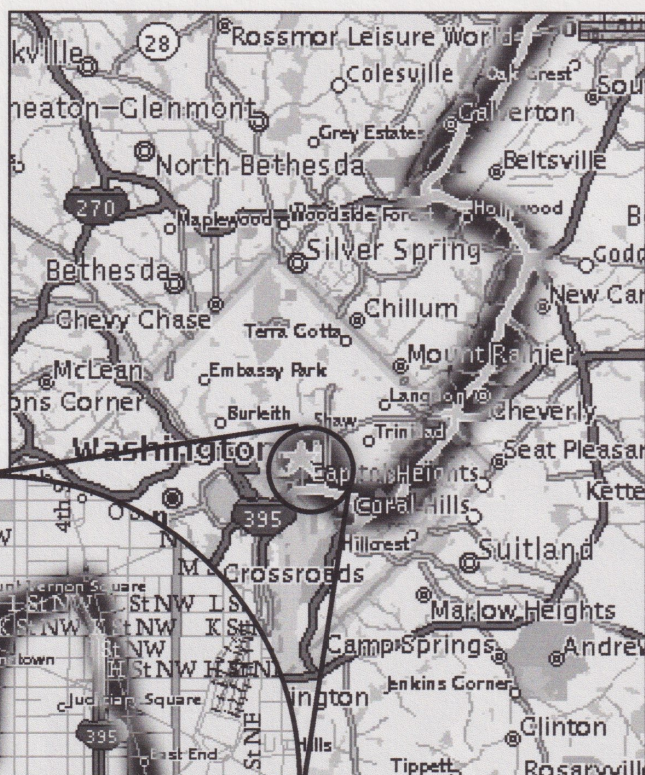
"We just got in an hour ago," I lit a cigarette, "from Rochester. So far, so good."

"How was the ride?"

The bartender interrupted our small talk before I could reply and distributed the glasses to everyone. It had only been about a half a minute since the order was placed.

"Skoal!" he announced as we slammed the first drink.

"Gambay!" Jason offered for the second toast.



The next seven shots went down.

"Provost!" I shouted as we lifted our final glasses.

"Nice meeting you, hope you have good time while in town," the man in the suit said. He and his friends got up and left the club just slow enough to hear us thank him.

The bartender appeared with two more pint glasses of White Russians, and said as almost if it was an apology, "These are on me."

We thanked her as intelligibly as we could and started to nurse our drinks. We had been there for fewer than ten minutes and hadn't walked passed the section of bar directly in front of the entrance. We finally had a chance to look around. The floors were vibrating with the steps of over 2000 feet, 1600 of which were attached to 800 of the most beautiful young women I have ever seen in three dimensions. While they were moving, there was

another 600 feet standing still and getting hammered. My pupils were dilating in sync with the strobes and cyberlights. The ceiling was over sixty feet above us and circling. Along the four walls' halfway point was a balcony level roughly twelve feet wide and supporting a circumnavigating crowd.

We ventured up there and found a row of booths, small meeting areas each with a table. All of them were packed to capacity except for one which had a large man, passed out, sleeping on his side. We sat down across from him.

"Look at that," I pointed to the man, who resembled a Blowfish that had lost its Hootie as he snored louder than the deafening music, "It's not even 12:30 and he's gone."

Jason agreed to my observation, "Some people just don't know when to quit." He then put a cigarette in the man's hand and lit it.

I laughed, "Don't be so cruel." Then I noticed something truly wonderful and a plan formed in my head. "Let's take a walk around."

We found a second set of stairs leading down into the basement where there was another bar. It used to be the bank vault. Now it is a lounge playing cool blue jazz. We sat down at one of the tables and I leaned forward into his ear as I told Jason what needed to be done next.

"We should go back to the balcony in a couple minutes. If the guy hasn't moved since we were there, keep an eye out to make sure no one's looking. You know, block me from the view of bouncers."

"What are you going to do?"

I smiled enigmatically, "It's best you don't know now. But we're going to have to leave immediately, but nonchalant."

He looked around and then up. I could tell he was thinking about the 1600 beautiful legs sweetly

sweating in the room above. His head angled down and his forehead, eyebrows and lower lip scrunched into a determined look signaling to me that the thought process had moved to the problem of conversation with any of those legs' owners. He relaxed his face and smacked his lips when he came to the quiet and personal conclusion that he was most likely a little too drunk to make a good first impression and sober enough to know it. This

was all silent, but I know my friends too well. "OK, I guess I'm ready to go."

We worked our way back up through the crowd to the booth. The man was still in the same position. The cigarette ash was two inches long. Jason turned away and assumed the stance of a drunken secret service man. Five seconds later I gave him a tap on the shoulder and we left. We smuggled ourselves to the car, got in, and shut the doors.

"What did you do to that guy?"

I turned the ignition and pulled out into the street. I reached into my back pocket. "If it wasn't me, someone else would've," I announced as I threw into his lap an overloaded eel skin wallet.

"What's this?"

"It was just stickin' right out of the top of his pocket. So, what'd we get?"

He opened it like an ancient tome. He didn't go



straight to the cash, but flipped through the pictures and credit cards, slow teasing both himself and me in a way that would make even a seven-vieled Solame impatient. "John Scott Templeton, lives in Vienna, West Virginia, born October 10, '72... hmmm... Libra."

"Year of the rat," I added.

"American Express Platinum member since February '95.

"He's got an okay looking girlfriend," he turned the photo over, "Janice. He must be looking for something better though... there's a few phone numbers in here: Samantha, Rhonda, Tracy, Denise..."

"Fat and ugly's getting numbers?"

He continued with more credit cards, "He's got Sunoco, Mobil, Discover, M & T..." He started laughing as he pulled out a card to show me it.

I chuckled too as I read it aloud: "Buy 10 Starbucks Frappuccinos get one free."

"It's a shame, Brian," Jason said as he examined it closer, "He only had one more to go."

I reached for the box on my dashboard that contained a stack of over eighty-five of those cards, officially stamped one day by a disgruntled employee who owed me twenty dollars. I took half the stack and handed it to Jason, "We'll send his wallet back with these in it; his cards, too." I was only interested in the money, and at that moment I made that fact clear with a nod and a rolling finger gesture.

Jason folded open the cash compartment, with an astonished, "Oh, look what we have here!" He pulled out a rolled-up sandwich bag containing a fine white powder with glints of sheen blue from an unseen light. He held it up and looked at me with a raised eyebrow as if to inquire what action I thought we should take.

I finally figured out the question that I recently thought would be plaguing me forever, "Now we know why he's so popular with the ladies. I'd bet he'd rape them when they're out cold." I had con-

vinced myself that I had delayed the inevitable dishonoring of these woman by a couple of months, "I was *destended* to steal his wallet."

Jason snapped me out, "Yeah, you did good, whatever. What should we do with this?"

I stopped at the light and carefully took the bag of powder, licked the tip of my finger, dipped it into the bag, and had a taste. It had a strong bitter flavor that clung to the back of my throat that cooled and liquified as it went slightly numb. "Cocaine... or crystal meth... Is meth numbing?" I asked seriously.

"Right now, I couldn't even tell by taste if it was drink mix," he paused, "Well, I don't want any, but it's okay by me if you want me to set you up with a line."

I rolled up the bag and tossed it into his lap. "Just see how much money we got."

I sped onto Interstate 95 North, back to the Scaggsville Rest Stop or the Stardust Go-Go Lounge. Our fate was not yet clear. He counted quietly: "One, two..." He paused, "five, six, seven" He paused again, this time taking a deep breath. "One, two, three, four, five, six, seven." He then stopped and looked at me, not saying anything more.

"How much?" I was getting anxious.

"Seven hundred and seventy-two dollars."

"Whoa," then I chuckled, "You know what I whispered to the guy before I took it?"

"What?"

I lowered my voice to an ironic lullaby, "Welcome to the big city." 

**TO BE CONTINUED IN NEXT
CEREAL:**

Panic & Revulsion in
WASHINGTON D.C.

-Part 6-

HOTEL CHLOROFORMULA

Maybe it was tennis elbow or maybe it was a lack of handweights at the gym, but the thing comes at me with all the force of a softball pitched by a six year old.

So I catch it.

We stand there looking at each other in astonishment for a few seconds, and then he speaks again: "Give that back!"

All I can do is laugh.

He repeats, a little more agitated this time, "Give that back!"

On most days I would have flung it back at him hard enough to bruise at least, or maybe just throw it on the ground, but not today. Today, I simply pocket the cellphone and walk away

**I CAN ONLY LAUGH
AT THIS POOR
PATHETIC FIGURE,
WHICH SEEMS ONLY
TO UPSET HIM
MORE.**

from his outstretched hand. I consider marching up to his car, pushing him aside, reaching into his BMW and emptying twelve ounces of Starbucks on his leather interior, but I decide against it at the last minute.

I just walk away.

I give the cellphone to an unsuspecting bum outside the 7-11, buy my Camels, and walk home feeling good because today I accomplished something.



Memo from the Editor

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g this ed. e to ere wh w n g Fee how l'sk you r e x!

CEREAL INGREDIENTS

PUBLISHER
C. DIABLO

EDITOR & LAYOUT
BRIAN BARRETT

WRITERS
BRIAN BARRETT
KYLE MAWHINEY
LUC TIERS

ILLUSTRATIONS
BRIAN BARRETT

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CEREAL@HELLSKITCHEN.ORG